AETHER: AI-ENHANCED THREAT ENUMERATION AND RECONNAISSANCE PLATFORM

A PROJECT REPORT

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in partial fulfillment for the award of the degree

of

BACHELOR OF ENGINEERING

IN

COMPUTER SCIENCE AND ENGINEERING (CYBER SECURITY)

R. M. K. COLLEGE OF ENGINEERING AND TECHNOLOGY

(An Autonomous Institution)

ANNA UNIVERSITY: CHENNAI 600 025

DECEMBER 2025

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

Support on demand, encouragement at the needed moment and guidance in the right direction are indispensable for the success of any project. We have received these in excess from all corners from various people, and we are glad to submit our gratitude to them.

We thank **Thiru. R. S. Munirathinam**, our beloved Chairman, and **Thiru. R. M. Kishore**, our Vice Chairman of RMK Group of Institutions for extending a generous hand in providing the best of resources to the college.

We express our sincere gratitude to **Dr. N. Suresh Kumar**, the esteemed Head of our Institution, for his continuous motivation and guidance to all the faculty members and students. We also extend our heartfelt thanks to **Dr. K. Sivaram**, Dean–Academics, and **Dr. K. Ramar**, Dean–Research, for their constant support and encouragement throughout the course of this project.
Our sincere thanks to **Dr. S.M Udhaya Sankar**, the Head of the Department for his continuous support and motivation throughout our project.

We extend our profound gratitude to **Dr.Dharini N**, Associate Professor, our Project Coordinator and _____, our Supervisor for her guidance, who has indeed been a pollster throughout the course of the project, we thank them for giving us full support to complete the project successfully.

Last, but not the least, we take this opportunity to thank all the staff members of the Department of Computer Science and Engineering (Cyber Security). Regards to our family, classmates and friends who offered an unflinching moral support for completion of this project.

ABSTRACT

The project aims to enhance cybersecurity reconnaissance and attack surface understanding through the development of AETHER, an AI-assisted, legally compliant web intelligence platform. The system focuses on automated discovery, mapping, and analysis of web assets by integrating focused crawling techniques, graph-based visualization, and controlled execution of security reconnaissance tools. AETHER employs crawler-driven site exploration to construct structured sitemaps and relationship graphs that capture the interconnections between web pages, endpoints, and resources. These graph representations provide a visual and analytical foundation for understanding complex web infrastructures and potential exposure points.

To enrich reconnaissance depth, the platform orchestrates the execution of Kali Linux command-line tools within a sandboxed worker environment, ensuring safe, authorized, and resource-controlled analysis. Outputs from crawling and reconnaissance processes are normalized into structured data models and stored securely for further analysis. Building upon this collected evidence, AETHER incorporates a Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) based conversational interface that enables users to query project-specific data and obtain contextual insights grounded in actual scan results. This AI-driven reasoning layer assists in summarizing findings, identifying patterns, and improving situational awareness without performing automated exploitation.

By combining focused crawling, graph-based intelligence, controlled automation, and AI-assisted reasoning, AETHER provides a comprehensive and scalable approach to external attack surface mapping. The platform emphasizes legal authorization, data integrity, and explainability, aiming to support security analysts, developers, and organizations in proactively understanding and reducing cyber risk. Through its modular design and visual-first analysis, AETHER contributes toward more transparent, interpretable, and responsible cybersecurity assessment practices.

Keywords: Cybersecurity reconnaissance, attack surface mapping, focused web crawling, graph visualization, Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG), AI-assisted security analysis

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

Acronym	Full Form
AETHER	Automated Ethical Threat Exploration and Reconnaissance
AI	Artificial Intelligence
API	Application Programming Interface
ASM	Attack Surface Management
CI/CD	Continuous Integration / Continuous Deployment
CLI	Command Line Interface
DB	Database
ER	Entity Relationship
HTTP	HyperText Transfer Protocol
HTTPS	HyperText Transfer Protocol Secure
IAM	Identity and Access Management
JSON	JavaScript Object Notation
LLM	Large Language Model
OSINT	Open Source Intelligence
RAG	Retrieval-Augmented Generation
RBAC	Role-Based Access Control
REST	Representational State Transfer
RFC	Request for Comments
SIEM	Security Information and Event Management
SQL	Structured Query Language
SSH	Secure Shell
UI	User Interface
URL	Uniform Resource Locator
VM	Virtual Machine
VPS	Virtual Private Server
XSS	Cross-Site Scripting

CHAPTER 1
INTRODUCTION

1.1 BACKGROUND OF THE STUDY

With the rapid expansion of the internet and cloud-based infrastructures, organizations increasingly rely on complex web applications, APIs, and distributed services to deliver functionality. While this digital transformation has enabled scalability and accessibility, it has also significantly expanded the external attack surface exposed to adversaries. Modern web environments consist of dynamic pages, third-party integrations, client-side scripts, hidden endpoints, and legacy components that are often poorly documented or overlooked.

Traditional security assessment practices primarily depend on manual reconnaissance or standalone automated scanners, which frequently operate in isolation and provide fragmented outputs. These methods often lack a unified view of discovered assets and fail to represent the interrelationships between web components in a comprehensible manner. As a result, security teams face challenges in understanding the true extent of their attack surface and prioritizing risks effectively.

Recent advances in automation, graph-based modeling, and artificial intelligence present opportunities to improve how reconnaissance data is collected, visualized, and interpreted. The AETHER project emerges within this context, aiming to provide a structured, visual, and AI-assisted approach to authorized web reconnaissance and attack surface mapping.

1.2 DOMAIN OVERVIEW

The domain of this project lies at the intersection of cybersecurity, web intelligence, and artificial intelligence. Specifically, AETHER operates within the following subdomains:

- **Web Security and Reconnaissance:** Identification of publicly accessible assets, endpoints, technologies, and configurations.

- **Focused Web Crawling:** Controlled exploration of websites to discover relevant pages and resources while minimizing noise and legal risk.
- **Graph-Based Security Analysis:** Representation of web assets and their relationships using node-edge models to enhance interpretability.
- **Security Automation:** Orchestration of reconnaissance tools for efficient and repeatable data collection.
- **AI-Assisted Reasoning (RAG):** Application of Retrieval-Augmented Generation to analyze and query collected security data contextually.

By combining these domains, AETHER aims to bridge the gap between raw reconnaissance outputs and actionable security understanding.

1.3 MOTIVATION OF THE PROJECT

The primary motivation behind AETHER is the lack of holistic visibility in existing reconnaissance workflows. Security practitioners often rely on multiple tools such as scanners, crawlers, and OSINT utilities, each producing disjointed outputs that require manual correlation. This process is time-consuming, error-prone, and difficult to scale.

Additionally, many modern platforms do not adequately address:

- Legal and ethical constraints of reconnaissance
- Visualization of attack surfaces for non-expert stakeholders
- Contextual reasoning over large volumes of scan data

AETHER is motivated by the need for a system that not only automates reconnaissance but also organizes, visualizes, and explains findings in a safe and intelligible manner. The integration of AI-based reasoning further motivates the project by enabling natural-language interaction with complex security data.

1.4 PROBLEM CONTEXT

Organizations frequently lack a clear and up-to-date understanding of their exposed web assets. Factors contributing to this problem include rapid development cycles, third-party services, shadow IT, and undocumented endpoints. Conventional tools generate extensive logs and reports but provide limited insight into how different components relate to one another or contribute to overall risk.

Furthermore, executing reconnaissance tools without proper isolation or authorization can lead to legal, ethical, and operational issues. Serverless platforms are unsuitable for heavy scanning tasks, while ad-hoc scripts lack standardization and safety controls.

The problem addressed by AETHER is the absence of a secure, scalable, and interpretable platform that combines focused crawling, automated reconnaissance, structured storage, and intelligent analysis under a unified architecture.

1.5 NEED OF THE SYSTEM/GAP ANALYSIS

Despite the availability of numerous security tools, several gaps remain:

- Fragmented Tooling: Existing scanners operate independently and do not provide a consolidated view.
- Poor Visualization: Limited support for graph-based representation of web structures and relationships.
- Lack of Contextual Intelligence: Raw outputs are difficult to interpret without expert knowledge.
- Scalability Constraints: Serverless platforms cannot support long-running reconnaissance tasks.
- Legal and Safety Oversight: Insufficient enforcement of authorization, rate limits, and target validation.

AETHER addresses these gaps by introducing a system that integrates crawling, scanning, visualization, and AI-assisted reasoning while enforcing strict safety and legal controls.

1.6 SCOPE OF THE PROJECT

The scope of AETHER includes:

- Authorized external web reconnaissance
- Focused crawling and sitemap generation
- Graph-based visualization of web assets and relationships
- Controlled execution of reconnaissance tools in a sandboxed environment
- Secure storage and retrieval of scan results
- AI-assisted querying and summarization using RAG techniques

The project does not include automated exploitation, payload delivery, or offensive attack execution. Its purpose is limited to analysis, visualization, and intelligence generation for defensive and educational use cases.

1.7 LIMITATIONS

While AETHER offers a comprehensive approach, certain limitations exist:

- Dependence on authorization restricts applicability to permitted targets only
- Crawling depth and scan coverage are limited by resource and time constraints
- AI-generated insights depend on the quality and completeness of collected data
- The system does not replace expert judgment or manual penetration testing
- RAG-based responses may require continuous tuning to avoid misinterpretation

These limitations highlight areas for future enhancement rather than deficiencies in system design.

1.8 CHAPTER SUMMARY

This chapter introduced the background, motivation, and problem context behind the AETHER project. It outlined the cybersecurity domain in which the system operates and identified critical gaps in existing reconnaissance approaches. The need for a unified, visual, and AI-assisted platform was established, along with the scope and limitations of the proposed system. Subsequent chapters will detail the system architecture, methodologies, implementation, and evaluation of AETHER.

CHAPTER 2
LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 INTRODUCTION TO LITERATURE REVIEW

A literature review provides a critical examination of existing research, technologies, and methodologies relevant to the proposed system. In the domain of cybersecurity reconnaissance and attack surface analysis, several studies have explored web crawling, vulnerability scanning, attack graph modeling, OSINT automation, and AI-assisted security analysis. However, most of these approaches remain fragmented, tool-centric, or theoretical in nature.

This chapter reviews prominent research works and existing systems related to web reconnaissance, security automation, graph-based analysis, and AI-driven cybersecurity intelligence. The limitations of these studies are identified, and the ways in which the proposed system, AETHER, addresses these limitations are clearly articulated.

2.2 EXISTING SYSTEMS

I. Paper Title: **Focused Crawling:** A New Approach to Topic-Specific Web Resource Discovery
Limitation: Focused primarily on information retrieval; does not address security reconnaissance or attack surface discovery.
Our Solution: AETHER adapts focused crawling techniques specifically for cybersecurity reconnaissance, prioritizing security-relevant endpoints and assets.

II. Paper Title: Graph Structure in the Web
Limitation: Provides only theoretical analysis of web graphs without practical security applications.
Our Solution: AETHER applies web graph theory practically by visualizing site structures and relationships to understand exposure and attack paths.

III. Paper Title: Tools for Generating and Analyzing Attack Graphs
Limitation: Requires formal models and static input data; not suitable for dynamic web environments.
Our Solution: AETHER dynamically generates graph structures from live crawl and scan data without requiring predefined attack models.

IV. Paper Title: Survey of Attack Graph Analysis Methods
Limitation: Focuses on analysis techniques but lacks integration with real-world data collection tools.
Our Solution: AETHER integrates automated data collection with graph-based analysis for end-to-end reconnaissance.

V. Paper Title: Automated Web Application Vulnerability Scanning: A Survey
Limitation: Evaluates scanners individually; does not address consolidation of outputs.
Our Solution: AETHER orchestrates multiple reconnaissance tools and normalizes outputs into a unified data model.

VI. Paper Title: Evaluating Open-Source Web Vulnerability Scanners
Limitation: Limited to benchmark environments and static targets.
Our Solution: AETHER supports real-world, authorized targets with configurable depth and scope.

VII. Paper Title: Attack Surface Management: A Survey
Limitation: Lacks visualization techniques for discovered assets.
Our Solution: AETHER introduces interactive graph-based visualization for attack surface understanding.

VIII. Paper Title: Automated OSINT Techniques for Cybersecurity
Limitation: OSINT data is collected passively without correlation to live systems.
Our Solution: AETHER correlates OSINT-style discovery with active crawling and scanning results.

IX. Paper Title: A Framework for Web Application Reconnaissance
Limitation: Uses static scripts with limited extensibility and safety controls.
Our Solution: AETHER employs a sandboxed worker architecture with enforced timeouts and authorization checks.

X. Paper Title: Vulnerability Assessment Using Nmap and Nikto
Limitation: Tool-centric and manual; no orchestration or visualization.
Our Solution: AETHER automates tool execution and visualizes results within project-specific graphs.

XI. Paper Title: Crawling and Indexing Dynamic Web Applications
Limitation: Focuses on functional crawling, not security-relevant discovery.
Our Solution: AETHER extracts security metadata such as headers, endpoints, and technologies during crawling.

XII. Paper Title: Security Automation in DevSecOps Pipelines
Limitation: Limited to CI/CD environments; does not support external attack surface mapping.
Our Solution: AETHER operates independently of CI/CD pipelines and targets external-facing assets.

XIII. Paper Title: Visualization Techniques for Network Security Analysis
Limitation: Primarily network-level; lacks application-layer context.
Our Solution: AETHER visualizes application-layer web structures and relationships.

XIV. Paper Title: Knowledge Graphs for Cybersecurity Applications
Limitation: Requires extensive manual curation of entities and relationships.
Our Solution: AETHER automatically generates graph data from crawl and scan outputs.

XV. Paper Title: Large Language Models for Cybersecurity Applications
Limitation: Susceptible to hallucinations and lacks grounding in real data.
Our Solution: AETHER uses Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) grounded in project-specific scan data.

XVI. Paper Title: Privacy Risks in Retrieval-Augmented Generation Systems
Limitation: Highlights risks but does not provide applied system design.
Our Solution: AETHER enforces access control, redaction, and project-level isolation in RAG pipelines.

XVII. Paper Title: Automated Risk Scoring for Vulnerability Management
Limitation: Relies solely on CVSS scores without contextual awareness.
Our Solution: AETHER prioritizes findings using contextual graph relationships

and asset relevance.

XVIII. Paper Title: Web Application Attack Graph Generation
Limitation: Depends on predefined vulnerability databases.
Our Solution: AETHER derives relationships dynamically from real reconnaissance data.

XIX. Paper Title: Security Assessment of Serverless Architectures
Limitation: Highlights limitations of serverless execution for heavy tasks.
Our Solution: AETHER separates orchestration (serverless) from execution (worker-based architecture).

XX. Paper Title: Machine Learning-Based Vulnerability Detection
Limitation: Requires large labeled datasets and lacks explainability.
Our Solution: AETHER uses AI for reasoning and summarization rather than opaque detection.

XXI. Paper Title: Automated Website Mapping Tools for Penetration Testing
Limitation: Produces flat lists without structural context.
Our Solution: AETHER constructs hierarchical sitemaps and relational graphs.

XXII. Paper Title: Ethical Considerations in Automated Security Testing
Limitation: Discusses ethics without enforcing controls at system level.
Our Solution: AETHER enforces authorization confirmation, logging, and legal safeguards by design.

2.3 METHODS USED IN PREVIOUS STUDIES

Previous studies primarily employed standalone vulnerability scanners, static crawlers, or theoretical graph models. Data collection and analysis were often treated as separate stages, with limited automation and minimal visualization. AI techniques were either absent or applied without grounding in real reconnaissance data.

2.4 COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS OF RELATED WORK

Compared to existing systems, AETHER uniquely combines focused crawling, tool orchestration, graph visualization, and AI-assisted reasoning within a single platform. While prior work addresses individual components, AETHER integrates them into a cohesive and operational framework.

2.5 LIMITATIONS OF EXISTING RESEARCH / SYSTEMS

Existing research suffers from fragmentation, lack of visualization, limited scalability, insufficient legal controls, and weak contextual intelligence. Most systems either overwhelm users with raw data or rely on assumptions that do not hold in real-world web environments.

2.6 SUMMARY OF FINDINGS FROM LITERATURE

The literature indicates a clear need for an integrated reconnaissance platform that unifies discovery, analysis, visualization, and reasoning. It also highlights the importance of safety, legality, and explainability, which are insufficiently addressed in existing solut**ions.**

2.7 CHAPTER SUMMARY

This chapter reviewed over twenty research works related to web reconnaissance, attack surface analysis, security automation, and AI-assisted cybersecurity. The limitations of existing systems were identified, and the proposed system, AETHER, was positioned as a comprehensive solution addressing these gaps. The next chapter presents the system architecture and methodology of AETHER.

CHAPTER 3

PROBLEM STATEMENT

3.1 STATEMENT OF THE PROBLEM

Modern organizations face increasing difficulty in maintaining a clear and accurate understanding of their external web attack surface. Rapid application development, third-party integrations, dynamic client-side content, and decentralized deployment models continuously introduce new exposed assets such as endpoints, APIs, subdomains, and undocumented pages. Existing security tools and research approaches largely operate in isolation, producing fragmented and unstructured outputs that are difficult to correlate and interpret.

Despite extensive research on web crawling (I, II), attack graph modeling (III, IV), and vulnerability scanning (V, VI), there is no unified system that integrates authorized reconnaissance, structured visualization, and contextual reasoning into a single operational platform. This gap results in poor visibility, inefficient analysis, and increased risk of overlooked security exposures.

3.2 PROBLEM DESCRIPTION

The problem addressed by this project can be described across four major dimensions:

- **Fragmented Reconnaissance Data** Existing scanners and crawlers generate large volumes of logs and reports without providing a consolidated representation of discovered assets and their relationships (V, X, XXI).
- **Lack of Structural Visibility** Most systems present findings as flat lists or textual reports, failing to represent the structural relationships between web pages, endpoints, and technologies (II, VII, XIII).

- **Limited Contextual Intelligence** Security analysts must manually interpret scan results, as traditional tools lack contextual reasoning or explainability mechanisms (XV, XVII).
- **Operational and Legal Constraints** Many reconnaissance approaches fail to enforce authorization, safety boundaries, or resource controls, increasing legal and ethical risks (XIX, XXII).

As a result, organizations are unable to efficiently map their attack surfaces or prioritize remediation efforts in a scalable and defensible manner.

3.3 RESEARCH / SYSTEM CHALLENGES

Based on the literature review, the following challenges are identified:

- **Scalability Challenge:** Focused crawling and scanning must scale without overwhelming infrastructure or violating rate limits (I, XI).
- **Data Integration Challenge:** Outputs from heterogeneous tools must be normalized into a unified data model (V, IX).
- **Visualization Challenge:** Representing complex web structures and relationships in an interpretable and interactive format remains difficult (II, XIII).
- **Automation Safety Challenge:** Automated reconnaissance must enforce authorization, scope boundaries, and execution isolation (XIX, XXII).
- **AI Reliability Challenge:** AI-based analysis systems risk hallucination and misinformation when not grounded in verified data (XV, XVI).

Addressing these challenges simultaneously is necessary to build a practical and trustworthy reconnaissance platform.

3.4 PROPOSED SOLUTION OUTLINE

To address the identified problems and challenges, this project proposes **AETHER**, a modular and legally compliant cybersecurity reconnaissance platform with the following key components:

- **Focused Crawling Engine** A controlled crawler discovers web assets and builds structured sitemaps while respecting authorization and scope constraints (I, XI).
- **Graph-Based Asset Representation** Discovered assets are represented as nodes and edges, enabling visual analysis of relationships and exposure paths (II, III).
- **Sandboxed Tool Orchestration** Security reconnaissance tools are executed in isolated worker environments with enforced timeouts and sanitized inputs (IX, XIX).
- **Unified Data Storage and Normalization** Crawl and scan outputs are converted into structured formats for consistent querying and visualization (V, XIV).
- **AI-Assisted Reasoning via RAG** A Retrieval-Augmented Generation layer allows users to query project-specific data using natural language while remaining grounded in actual evidence (XV, XVI).

Through this architecture, AETHER transforms raw reconnaissance data into actionable, explainable, and visually interpretable intelligence.

3.5 CHAPTER SUMMARY

This chapter defined the core problem addressed by the AETHER project: the lack of an integrated, scalable, and interpretable system for authorized web attack surface reconnaissance. Drawing from existing research on focused crawling (I), web graph structures (II), attack graph analysis (III, IV), vulnerability scanning (V, VI), and AI-assisted security analysis (XV, XVI), several limitations and challenges were identified. The proposed solution, AETHER, addresses these gaps by unifying crawling, tool orchestration, graph visualization, and AI-driven reasoning within a secure and legally compliant framework. The next chapter presents the detailed system architecture and methodology adopted for implementing the proposed solution.

CHAPTER 4

OBJECTIVES

4.1 PRIMARY OBJECTIVES

The primary objectives of the AETHER project are focused on addressing the core challenges identified in earlier chapters and establishing a robust foundation for authorized cybersecurity reconnaissance. The primary objectives are as follows:

1. To design and develop a unified platform for **authorized web attack surface discovery and reconnaissance**.
2. To implement a **focused web crawling mechanism** capable of discovering security-relevant web assets while minimizing unnecessary data collection.
3. To construct **graph-based representations** of web assets and their relationships for enhanced visibility and interpretability.
4. To enable **controlled orchestration of cybersecurity reconnaissance tools** within a sandboxed and resource-limited execution environment.
5. To ensure **legal compliance, safety, and authorization enforcement** throughout the reconnaissance process.
6. To integrate **AI-assisted reasoning** using Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) for contextual analysis and explanation of collected security data.

4.2 SECONDARY OBJECTIVES

The secondary objectives support the primary goals by enhancing usability, scalability, and analytical depth:

1. To provide an **interactive and user-friendly frontend** for managing projects, scans, and results visualization.
2. To normalize and store reconnaissance outputs in **structured and queryable data formats**.
3. To support **historical tracking and comparison** of reconnaissance results across multiple scans.
4. To enable **natural language querying** of reconnaissance data through a conversational interface.

5. To incorporate **basic prioritization and risk indicators** based on asset relevance and connectivity.
6. To ensure system **modularity and extensibility** for future integration of additional tools and analysis modules.

4.3 EXPECTED OUTCOME

Upon successful implementation, the AETHER project is expected to achieve the following outcomes:

- A functional platform capable of performing **authorized external reconnaissance** on web applications and domains.
- Generation of **structured sitemaps and interactive graphs** that clearly represent web asset relationships.
- Automated and safe execution of reconnaissance tools with **centralized result management**.
- Improved **situational awareness** through AI-assisted summaries and contextual explanations grounded in real scan data.
- Reduction in manual effort required to interpret reconnaissance results.
- A scalable and reusable framework suitable for **defensive security assessment, education, and research purposes**.

4.4 CHAPTER SUMMARY

This chapter outlined the primary and secondary objectives of the AETHER project, emphasizing its focus on authorized reconnaissance, structured visualization, and AI-assisted analysis. The expected outcomes highlight the system's ability to transform fragmented reconnaissance outputs into actionable and interpretable security intelligence. The next chapter will describe the system architecture and methodological approach adopted to achieve these objectives.

CHAPTER 5

PROPOSED SYSTEM

5.1 OVERVIEW OF PROPOSED SYSTEM

The proposed system, **AETHER**, is a modular and legally compliant cybersecurity reconnaissance platform designed to identify, map, and analyze the external attack surface of web-based applications. The system integrates focused web crawling, controlled execution of security reconnaissance tools, graph-based visualization, and AI-assisted reasoning into a unified framework.

Unlike traditional standalone scanners, AETHER emphasizes **structural visibility**, **safe automation**, and **contextual intelligence**. The system separates orchestration from execution by utilizing a serverless API layer for coordination and a sandboxed worker environment for resource-intensive reconnaissance tasks. All collected data is securely stored and later analyzed using graph models and Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) techniques.

5.2 BLOCK DIAGRAM

The block diagram of the proposed system consists of the following major components:

1. User Interface (Frontend)
2. API & Orchestration Layer
3. Authentication & Database Layer
4. Worker / Execution Engine
5. Crawler & Sitemap Generator
6. Graph Visualization Engine
7. AI-Assisted Analysis (RAG Layer)

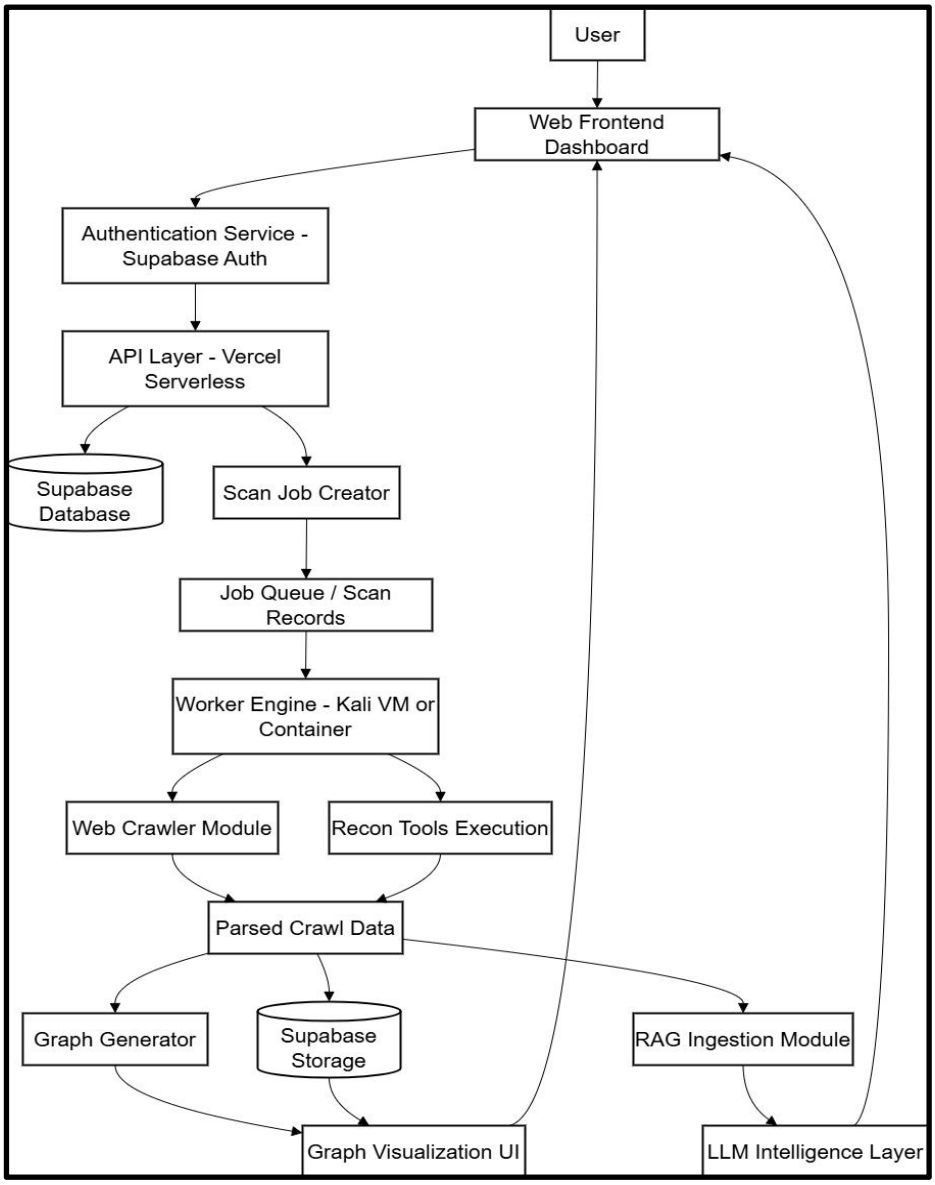

Figure 5.1: Flow Map / Block Diagram

Data Flow Description:

User → Frontend → API Layer → Job Queue → Worker Engine → Crawler / Recon Tools → Structured Data Storage → Graph Visualization + AI Reasoning → User

This flow ensures that user interactions remain lightweight while heavy reconnaissance tasks are executed in isolated environments.

5.3 SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE

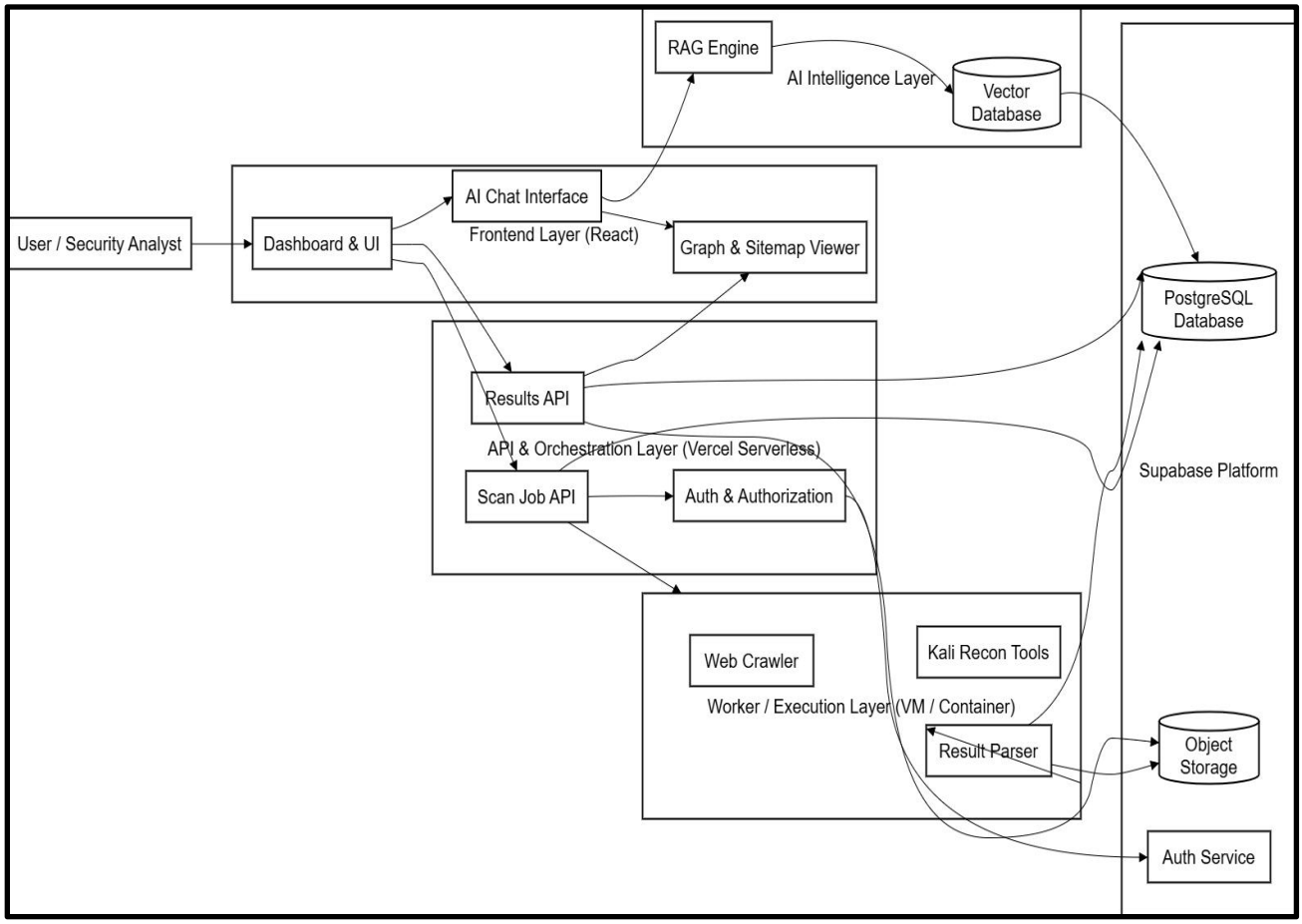

Figure 5.2: System Architecture

The system architecture of AETHER follows a **distributed, service-oriented design**, consisting of the following layers:

1. Presentation Layer

- React-based frontend
- Provides project creation, scan initiation, result visualization, and chatbot interface

2. API & Orchestration Layer

- Serverless API (Vercel)
- Handles authentication, job creation, job status queries, and result retrieval

- Does not perform long-running reconnaissance tasks

3. Authentication & Storage Layer

- Supabase Authentication for secure user access
- PostgreSQL database for metadata
- Object storage for scan outputs and crawl artifacts

4. Worker / Execution Layer

- Self-hosted VM or containerized environment
- Executes Kali Linux reconnaissance tools
- Enforces timeouts, resource limits, and input sanitization

5. Intelligence Layer

- Graph engine for asset relationship modeling
- RAG-based AI layer for contextual querying and summarization

This layered architecture ensures scalability, safety, and maintainability.

5.4 FUNCTIONAL DESCRIPTION

The functional operation of the proposed system is described below:

1. The user logs in and creates a project using the frontend interface.
2. The user submits a scan request with authorized target details.
3. The API layer validates the request and creates a scan job.
4. The worker engine retrieves the job and performs:
   a) Focused crawling
   b) Tool-based reconnaissance
5. Results are parsed and stored in structured formats.
6. A sitemap and graph representation are generated.
7. The user views interactive visualizations and queries the data using the AI interface.

Each function is executed within defined scope and safety constraints.

5.5 MODULES / COMPONENTS OVERVIEW

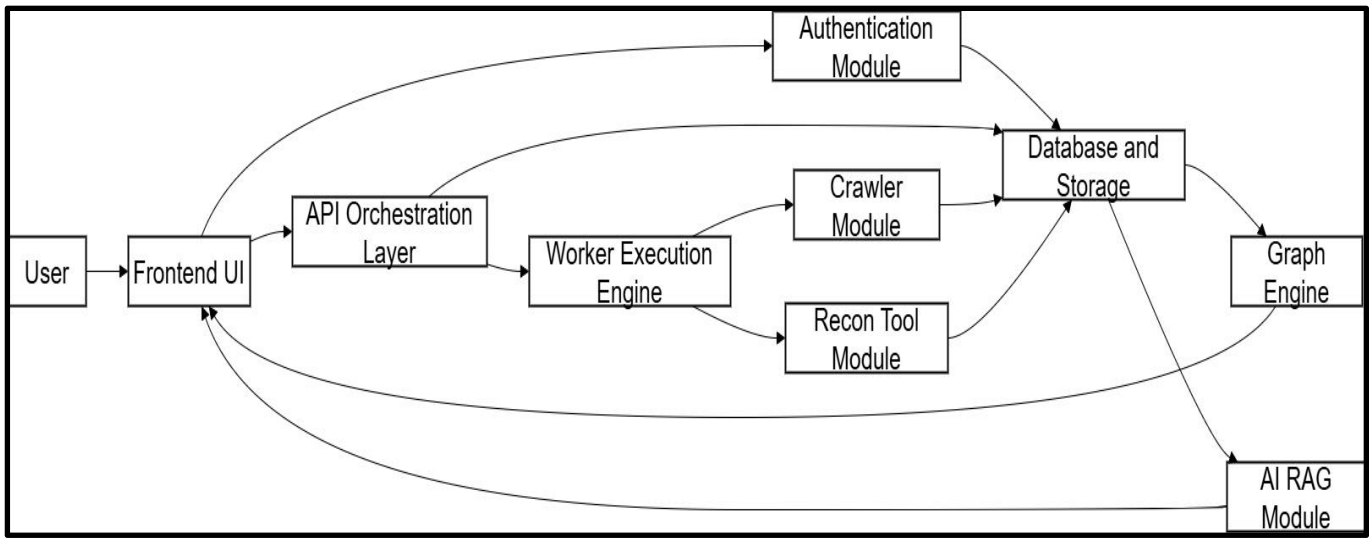

Figure 5.3: Modular Architecture View

1. User Interface Module

- Project dashboard
- Scan controls
- Graph and sitemap viewers
- Chatbot interface

2. Authentication Module

- User login and access control
- Project ownership enforcement

3. Crawler Module

- Discovers internal pages and endpoints
- Respects scope, depth, and authorization limits

4. Reconnaissance Module

- Executes tools such as Nmap, Nikto, and WhatWeb
- Collects service and configuration information

5. Data Normalization Module

- Converts raw outputs into structured JSON
- Ensures consistency across tools

6. Graph Engine Module

- Constructs node-edge models
- Supports interactive visualization

7. AI Reasoning Module

- Uses RAG to answer project-specific queries
- Grounds responses in stored reconnaissance data

5.6 ADVANTAGES OF PROPOSED SYSTEM

The proposed system offers several advantages over existing approaches:

- **Unified Platform:** Integrates crawling, scanning, visualization, and AI reasoning
- **Legal and Ethical Compliance:** Enforces authorization and scope control
- **Improved Visibility:** Graph-based visualization enhances understanding
- **Scalability:** Separation of orchestration and execution enables efficient scaling
- **Explainability:** AI responses are grounded in real data
- **Modularity:** Supports future extensions and additional tools

5.7 CHAPTER SUMMARY

This chapter presented the proposed system architecture and design of AETHER. It described the overall system flow, block diagram, architectural layers, functional operation, and core modules. The advantages of the proposed system highlight its effectiveness in providing a secure, scalable, and interpretable solution for authorized web reconnaissance. The next chapter will focus on the implementation details of the system.

CHAPTER 6

SYSTEM DESIGN

6.1 INTRODUCTION TO SYSTEM DESIGN

System design defines the structural blueprint of the AETHER platform, detailing how system components interact, how data flows across modules, and how functional and non-functional requirements are achieved. This chapter presents the Unified Modeling Language (UML) diagrams, database design, and technical requirements that collectively describe the internal working of the proposed system.

The design of AETHER follows a **modular, scalable, and secure architecture**, ensuring separation of concerns between orchestration, execution, visualization, and intelligence layers.

6.2.1 USE CASE DIAGRAM

Actors:

- User (Security Analyst / Researcher)
- System Administrator
- Worker Node (Execution Engine)

Use Cases:

- Register / Login
- Create Project
- Define Scope and Authorization
- Initiate Scan
- View Scan Results
- Visualize Attack Surface Graph
- Query Results using AI
- Manage Users (Admin)
- Monitor Worker Status

Description: The user interacts with the system to create projects, initiate scans, and analyze results. The worker node executes reconnaissance tasks, while the administrator manages system configurations.

6.2.2 CLASS DIAGRAM

Actors:

- User (Security Analyst / Researcher)
- System Administrator
- Worker Node (Execution Engine)

Use Cases:

- Register / Login
- Create Project
- Define Scope and Authorization
- Initiate Scan
- View Scan Results
- Visualize Attack Surface Graph
- Query Results using AI
- Manage Users (Admin)
- Monitor Worker Status

Description: The user interacts with the system to create projects, initiate scans, and analyze results. The worker node executes reconnaissance tasks, while the administrator manages system configurations.

6.2.3 SEQUENCE DIAGRAM

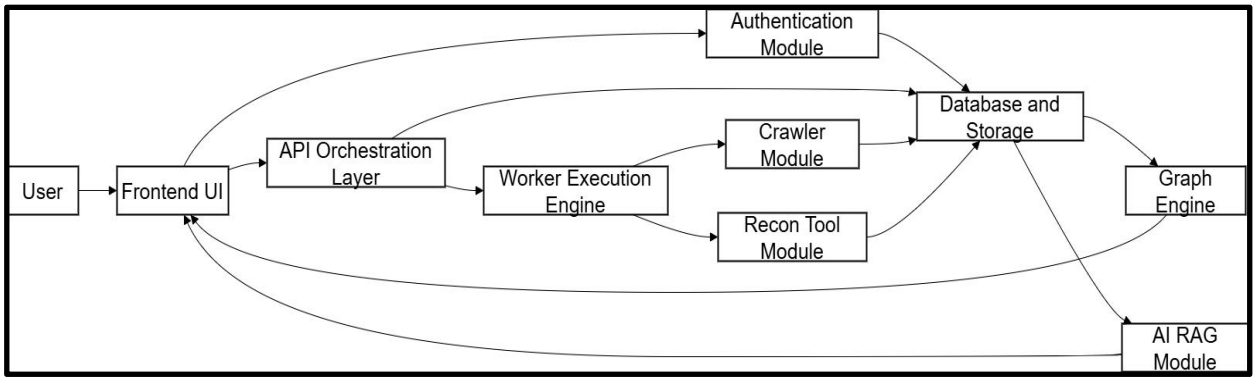

Figure 6.1: Sequence Diagram

Sequence: Initiate and Execute Scan

1. User submits scan request via Frontend
2. API validates authorization and scope
3. API creates scan job
4. Worker fetches job from queue
5. Worker executes crawler and tools
6. Results are parsed and stored
7. Graph is generated
8. User retrieves and views results

This sequence ensures asynchronous execution and responsiveness.

6.2.4 ACTIVITY DIAGRAM

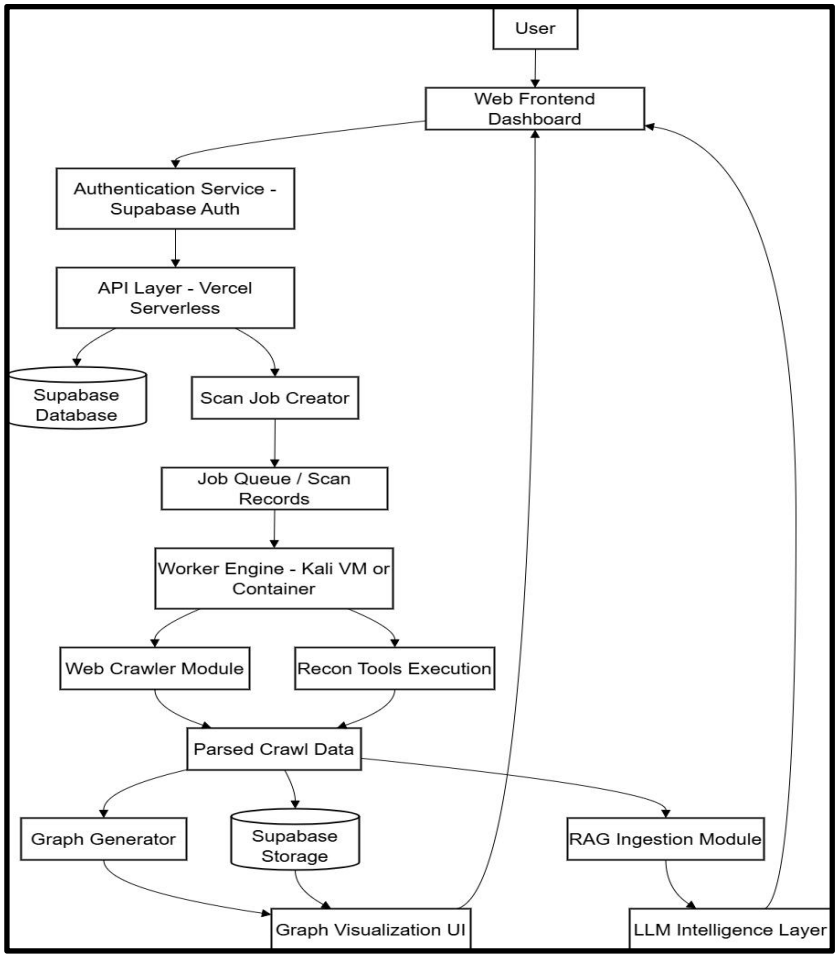

Figure 6.2: Activity Diagram

Activities:

- Start
- User Login
- Project Selection
- Scan Configuration
- Authorization Validation
- Recon Execution
- Data Processing
- Visualization
- End

Decision nodes ensure scope validation and error handling during execution.

6.2.5 COMPONENT DIAGRAM

Components:

- Frontend (React UI)
- API Gateway
- Auth Service
- Job Queue
- Worker Engine
- Recon Tools
- Database
- Graph Engine
- AI Module

Each component communicates through defined interfaces, supporting loose coupling.

6.3 DATABASE DESIGN

The database design ensures efficient storage, retrieval, and correlation of reconnaissance data.

6.3.1 ER DIAGRAM

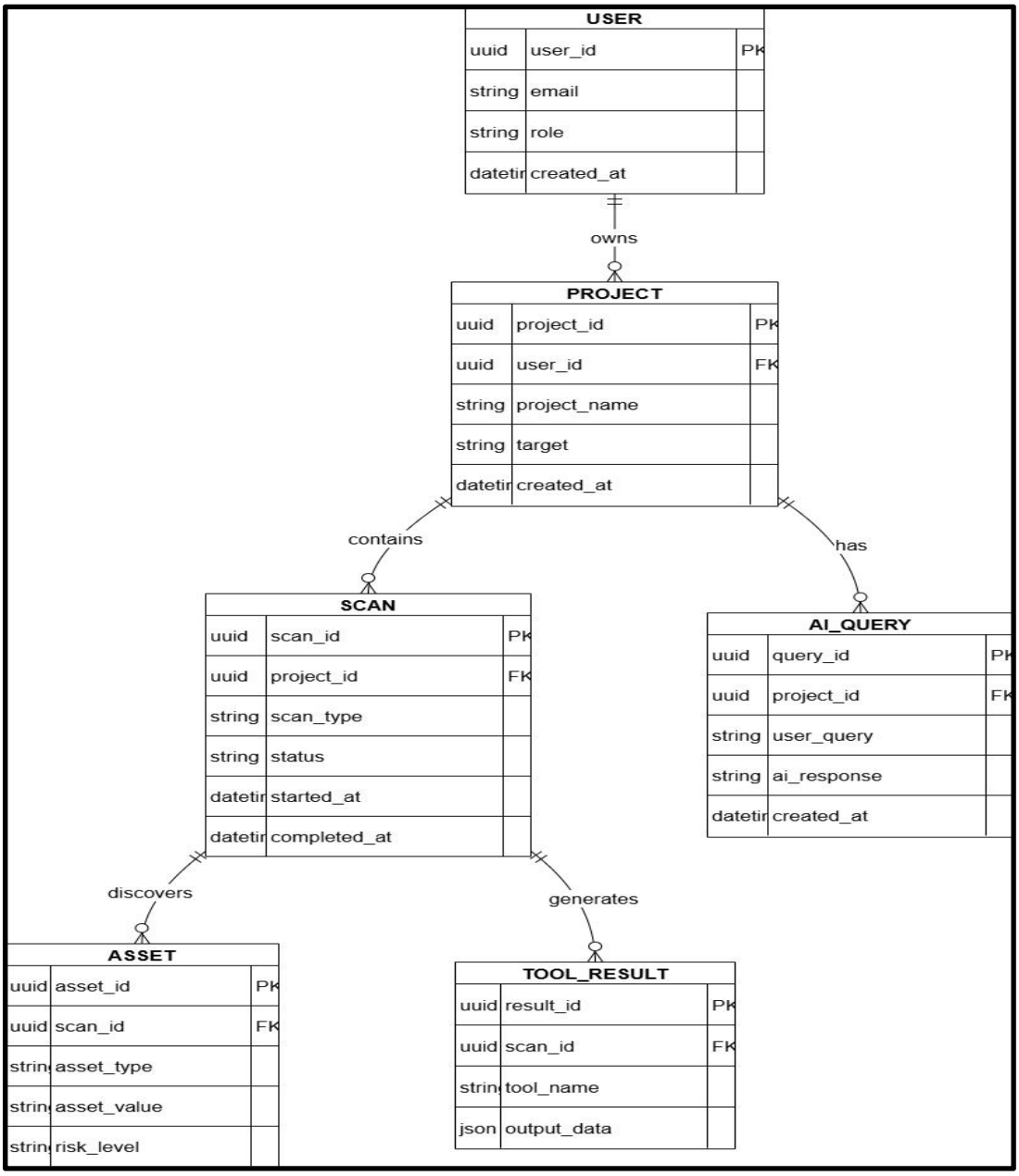

Figure 6.3: ER Diagram

Entities:

- User
- Project
- Scan
- Asset
- ToolResult
- Graph
- AIQuery

Relationships:

- User → Project (1:N)
- Project → Scan (1:N)
- Scan → Asset (1:N)
- Scan → ToolResult (1:N)

6.3.2 SCHEMA DIAGRAM

Schema Overview:

- users(user_id, email, role)
- projects(project_id, user_id, target)
- scans(scan_id, project_id, status)
- assets(asset_id, scan_id, type)
- tool_results(result_id, scan_id, tool_name)
- graph_nodes(node_id, asset_id)
- graph_edges(edge_id, source, target)
- ai_queries(query_id, scan_id)

6.3.3 TABLE DEFINITIONS

Users Table

- user_id (PK)
- email
- password_hash
- role
- created_at

Projects Table

- project_id (PK)
- user_id (FK)
- target_domain
- created_at

Scans Table

- scan_id (PK)
- project_id (FK)
- status
- started_at
- completed_at

Assets Table

- asset_id (PK)
- scan_id (FK)
- asset_type
- asset_value

Tool_Results Table

- result_id (PK)
- scan_id (FK)
- tool_name
- output_json

6.4 HARDWARE REQUIREMENTS

- Processor: Intel i5 / Ryzen 5 or higher
- RAM: Minimum 8 GB (16 GB recommended)
- Storage: 50 GB free disk space
- Network: Stable internet connection
- Optional: Cloud VM for worker execution

6.5 SOFTWARE REQUIREMENTS

- Operating System: Linux (Ubuntu/Kali), Windows for frontend
- Frontend: React.js, Tailwind CSS
- Backend: Node.js / Serverless Functions
- Database: PostgreSQL (Supabase)
- Containerization: Docker
- Recon Tools: Nmap, Nikto, WhatWeb
- AI: LLM with RAG integration
- Visualization: D3.js / Cytoscape.js

6.6 CHAPTER SUMMARY

This chapter presented the detailed system design of the AETHER platform, including UML diagrams, database architecture, and technical requirements. The design emphasizes modularity, scalability, and security, ensuring that AETHER can efficiently perform authorized reconnaissance while maintaining data integrity and user safety. The next chapter will discuss the implementation details and execution workflow of the system.

CHAPTER 7

MODULE DESCRIPTION

The AETHER system is designed using a modular architecture to ensure scalability, maintainability, and clarity of responsibilities. Each module performs a specific function within the overall system while interacting seamlessly with other modules. This chapter describes the objectives, functionality, inputs, outputs, algorithms, interfaces, and APIs used in each module.

MODULE 1: USER AUTHENTICATION & AUTHORIZATION MODULE

7.1 Module Objectives

- To securely authenticate users accessing the system.
- To enforce role-based access control for projects and scans.
- To ensure that only authorized users can initiate reconnaissance activities.

7.2 Module Overview

This module manages user registration, login, session handling, and authorization using Supabase Authentication. It validates user identity before granting access to system resources such as projects, scan results, and AI queries.

7.3 Input & Output Description

Input:

- User credentials (email, password)
- Authentication tokens

Output:

- Authenticated user session
- Access tokens
- Authorization status

7.4 Algorithms / Logic Used

- Email-password authentication
- JWT-based session validation
- Role-based access checks

7.5 API / Functions Used

- Supabase Auth API
- JWT verification functions
- Session middleware

MODULE 2: PROJECT MANAGEMENT MODULE

7.1 Module Objectives

- To allow users to create and manage multiple reconnaissance projects.
- To store project metadata and scope definitions.

7.2 Module Overview

This module enables users to define targets, project names, and scope details. Each project acts as a container for scans, assets, and reports.

7.3 Input & Output Description

Input:

- Project name
- Target domain
- Scope authorization confirmation

Output:

- Project ID
- Project metadata

7.4 Algorithms / Logic Used

- Input validation
- Database insertion logic
- Ownership verification

7.5 API / Functions Used

- POST /api/projects
- GET /api/projects/:id
- Supabase database client

MODULE 3: SCAN ORCHESTRATION MODULE

7.1 Module Objectives

- To manage scan job creation and lifecycle.
- To coordinate communication between frontend and worker nodes.

7.2 Module Overview

This module handles scan requests, queues jobs, tracks execution status, and ensures that long-running tasks are executed asynchronously.

7.3 Input & Output Description

Input:

- Scan configuration
- Selected scan types
- Target URL

Output:

- Scan job ID
- Scan status updates

7.4 Algorithms / Logic Used

- Job queuing
- State transition logic (queued → running → completed)

7.5 API / Functions Used

- POST /api/projects/:id/scan
- GET /api/scans/:id/status

MODULE 4: RECONNAISSANCE & TOOL EXECUTION MODULE

7.1 Module Objectives

- To perform controlled execution of security reconnaissance tools.
- To collect technical metadata without exploitation.

7.2 Module Overview

This module executes Kali Linux CLI tools such as Nmap, WhatWeb, and Nikto within a sandboxed worker environment. Outputs are parsed and stored securely.

7.3 Input & Output Description

Input:

- Target domain
- Tool parameters

Output:

- Raw tool outputs
- Parsed JSON results

7.4 Algorithms / Logic Used

- Subprocess execution with timeout
- Input sanitization

- Output parsing and normalization

7.6 API / Functions Used

- Python subprocess module
- Tool-specific CLI commands
- Worker REST API

MODULE 5: WEB CRAWLER & SITEMAP GENERATION MODULE

7.1 Module Objectives

- To discover web pages and endpoints within defined scope.
- To generate structured sitemaps and relationships.

7.2 Module Overview

This module crawls the target website using controlled depth and scope, extracting links, metadata, and response headers to build a sitemap.

7.3 Input & Output Description

Input:

- Seed URL
- Crawl depth

Output:

- Sitemap nodes
- URL relationships

7.4 Algorithms / Logic Used

- Breadth-First Search (BFS)
- URL normalization
- Duplicate detection

7.5 API / Functions Used

- HTTP request handlers
- Link extraction utilities

MODULE 6: GRAPH VISUALIZATION MODULE

7.1 Module Objectives

- To visually represent attack surface relationships.
- To improve interpretability of complex web structures.

7.2 Module Overview

This module converts sitemap data into graph nodes and edges and renders them using interactive visualization libraries.

7.3 Input & Output Description

Input:

- Sitemap JSON
- Asset relationships

Output:

- Interactive graph visualization

7.4 Algorithms / Logic Used

- Graph layout algorithms
- Node clustering
- Edge filtering

7.5 API / Functions Used

- Cytoscape.js
- D3.js
- Graph rendering utilities

MODULE 7: AI-BASED RAG & CHAT MODULE

7.1 Module Objectives

- To provide contextual insights using collected scan data.
- To enable natural language querying of project results.

7.2 Module Overview

This module integrates Retrieval-Augmented Generation to answer user queries grounded in stored reconnaissance data.

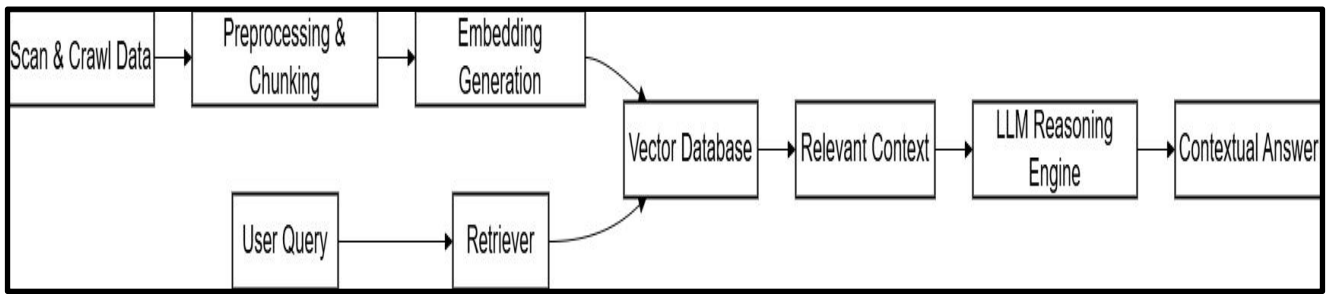

Figure 7.1: RAG Flow

7.3 Input & Output Description

Input:

- User queries
- Embedded project data

Output:

- Context-aware responses
- Evidence-backed explanations

7.4 Algorithms / Logic Used

- Text chunking
- Vector embeddings
- Similarity search
- LLM response generation

7.5 API / Functions Used

- Embedding APIs
- Vector database queries
- LLM inference endpoints

CHAPTER SUMMARY

This chapter detailed the functional modules of the AETHER system, outlining their objectives, workflows, inputs, outputs, algorithms, interfaces, and APIs. The modular design ensures scalability, security, and ease of enhancement. Each module collectively contributes to building a comprehensive, AI-assisted cybersecurity reconnaissance platform.

CHAPTER 8

IMPLEMENTATION

8.1 Implementation Details

The implementation of **AETHER** follows a modular and layered approach to ensure scalability, maintainability, and secure execution of reconnaissance tasks. The system is implemented using a combination of frontend technologies for user interaction, serverless APIs for orchestration, and isolated worker environments for executing reconnaissance tools.

The frontend is responsible for user authentication, project management, scan initiation, visualization of results, and interaction with the AI-based query system. The backend API layer handles request validation, authorization checks, job creation, and coordination between the frontend and the worker nodes. The worker module is implemented as a separate execution environment to safely run security tools and crawlers without exposing the core system to risks associated with long-running or resource-intensive processes.

All collected data is normalized and stored in a centralized database and object storage, enabling efficient retrieval, visualization, and AI-assisted analysis.

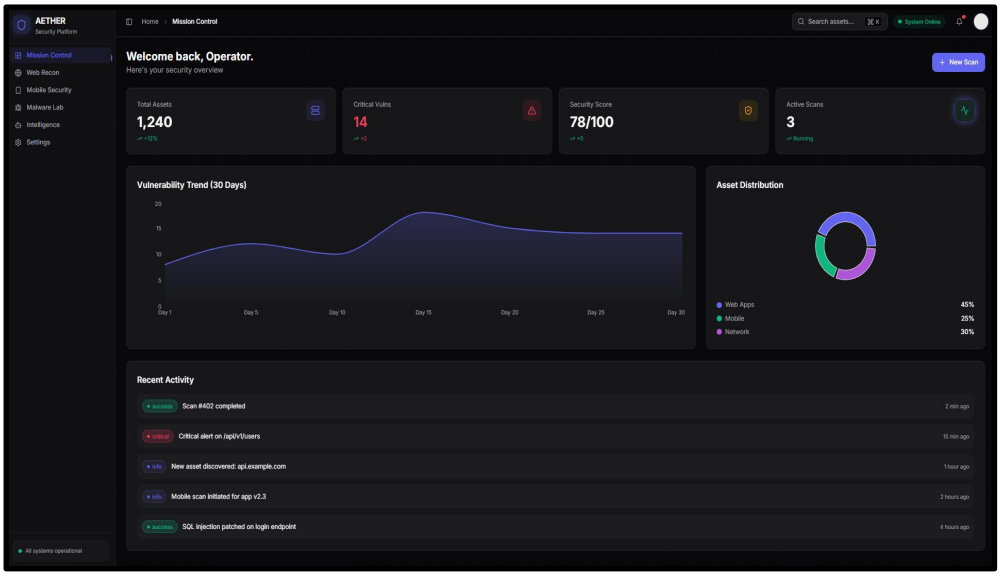

Figure 8.1: Dashboard

8.2 Technology Stack

The following technology stack is used for the implementation of AETHER:

Frontend:

- React.js
- Tailwind CSS
- Cytoscape.js (Graph Visualization)
- Supabase Client SDK

Backend / API Layer:

- Node.js
- Serverless Functions (Vercel / Next.js API Routes)
- RESTful APIs

Worker Environment:

- Python
- Kali Linux Tools (Nmap, Nikto, WhatWeb, Dirsearch)
- Scrapy / Playwright (Web Crawling)
- Docker (Containerization)

Database & Storage:

- PostgreSQL (Supabase)
- Supabase Storage (Object Storage)

AI & Intelligence Layer:

- Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)
- Vector Databases (FAISS / Chroma)
- Large Language Models (LLMs)

8.3 System Configuration

Hardware Configuration:

- Minimum 8 GB RAM
- Multi-core processor
- Internet connectivity
- Optional cloud VM for worker execution

Software Configuration:

- Operating System: Linux (Ubuntu / Kali)
- Node.js v18+
- Python v3.9+
- Docker Engine
- PostgreSQL Database

Security Configuration:

- Role-based authentication
- Secure API keys
- Restricted network access for worker nodes
- Target validation and authorization enforcement

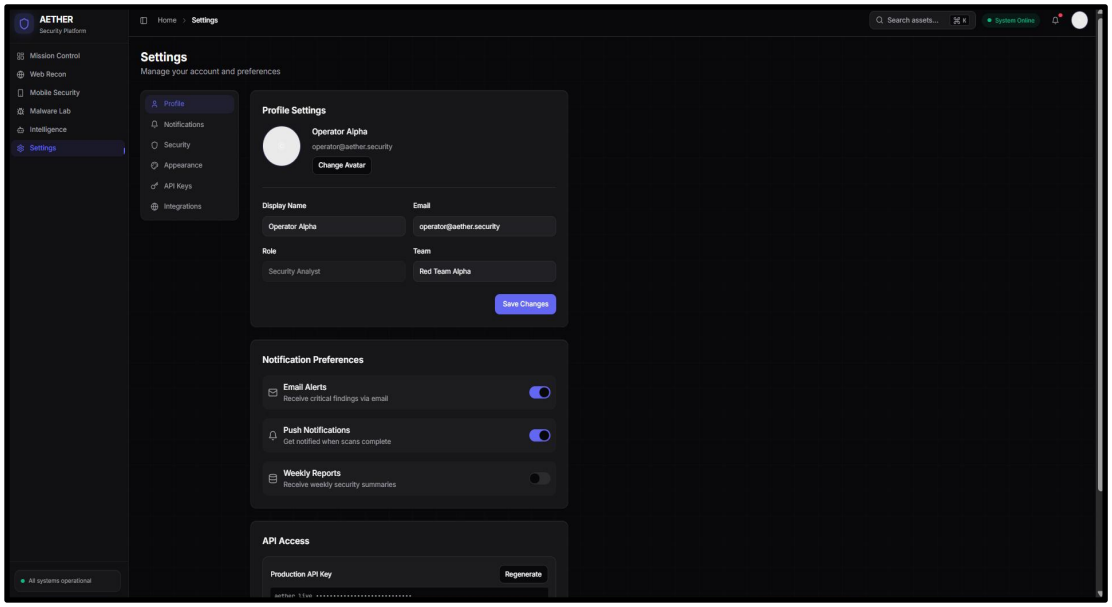

Figure 8.2: User Settings

8.4 Step-by-Step Implementation Flow

1. User registers and logs into the system using secure authentication.
2. User creates a new project and defines the target domain.
3. Authorization and scope confirmation is enforced before scan initiation.
4. User configures scan type (reconnaissance, crawling, visualization).
5. Backend API validates inputs and creates a scan job.
6. Scan job is queued and picked up by the worker node.
7. Worker executes crawler and reconnaissance tools with enforced limits.
8. Raw outputs are parsed into structured JSON format.
9. Sitemap and graph data are generated from crawl results.
10. Results are stored securely in the database and storage.
11. Frontend fetches and visualizes the results.
12. AI module enables contextual querying of collected data.

8.5 Testing Procedure

The system was tested using a combination of functional, integration, and security testing approaches.

Functional Testing:

- User authentication
- Project creation
- Scan initiation and completion
- Graph visualization
- AI query responses

Integration Testing:

- API to worker communication
- Database updates
- Storage retrieval

Security Testing:

- Input sanitization
- Scope validation
- Unauthorized access prevention
- Rate limiting enforcement

Performance Testing:

- Scan execution time
- API response latency
- Graph rendering efficiency

8.6 Chapter Summary

This chapter detailed the implementation of the AETHER system, including the technology stack, system configuration, execution flow, and testing procedures. The modular architecture and secure execution model ensure efficient reconnaissance while maintaining legal and ethical compliance. The successful implementation validates the feasibility of integrating automated reconnaissance, graph-based visualization, and AI-assisted analysis into a unified cybersecurity intelligence platform. The next chapter discusses the results, performance evaluation, and comparative analysis of the system.

CHAPTER 9

RESULTS AND DISCUSSIONS

9.1 Output Screenshots

The AETHER system generates multiple visual and textual outputs during execution. The following screenshots are to be included in the final report:

1. User Authentication and Dashboard Screen
2. Project Creation and Target Authorization Screen
3. Scan Configuration Interface
4. Scan Progress and Status Monitoring Screen
5. Sitemap Tree Visualization
6. Attack Surface Graph Visualization
7. Tool Output Summary (Nmap, WhatWeb, Crawler Results)
8. AI-Assisted Query and Response Interface

These screenshots collectively demonstrate the end-to-end functionality of the system, from project initiation to intelligence-driven analysis.

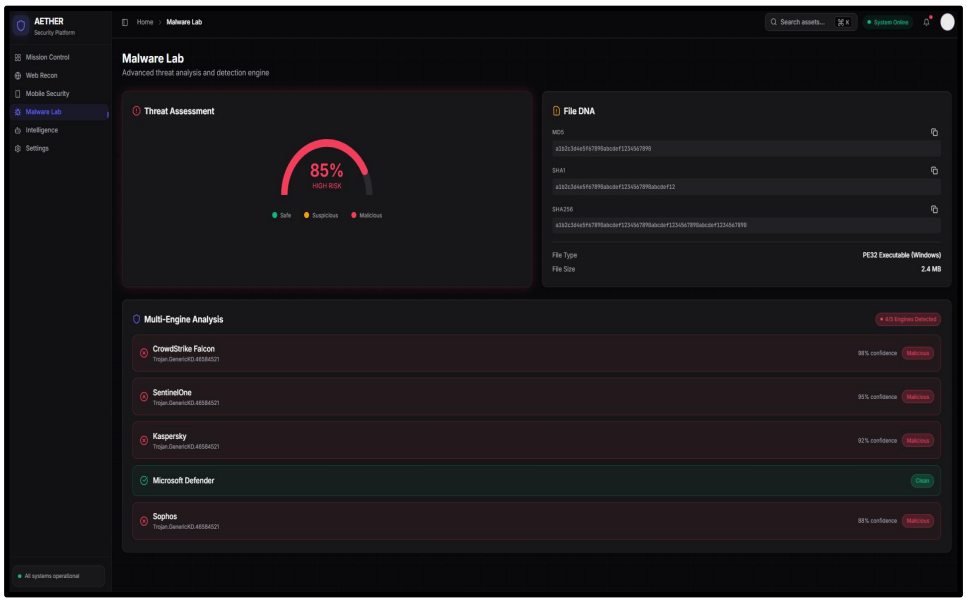

Figure 9.1 : Malware Report

9.2 Output Explanation

Upon successful authentication, users are able to create projects and define authorized targets. After initiating a scan, the system orchestrates crawling and reconnaissance tasks using the worker engine. The outputs include:

- A **structured sitemap** representing discovered URLs and resources
- A **graph-based visualization** showing relationships between pages, endpoints, and assets
- **Parsed reconnaissance results**, including open ports, technologies detected, headers, and metadata
- **AI-generated contextual responses**, derived using Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) over collected data

The outputs are presented in an intuitive visual format, enabling users to easily interpret complex reconnaissance information.

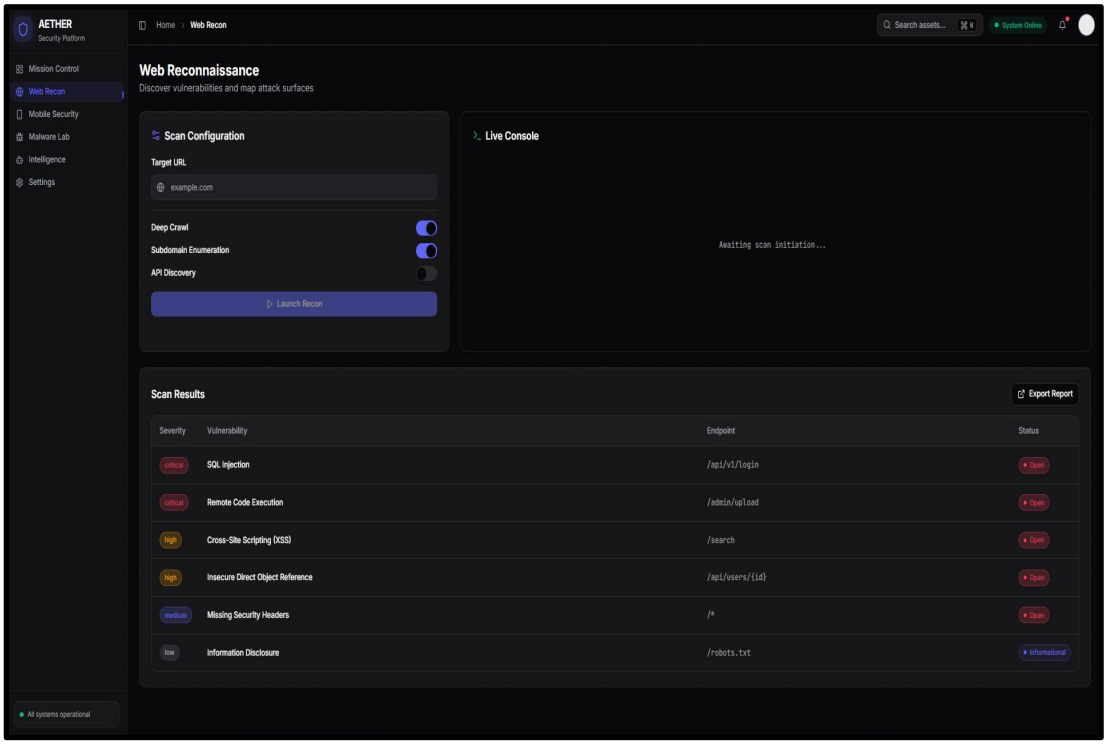

Figure 9.2 : Web Recon

9.3 Performance Evaluation

The performance of AETHER was evaluated based on the following parameters:

- Scan Completion Time
- Resource Utilization
- Crawl Coverage
- Visualization Responsiveness
- AI Query Accuracy

Observations:

- Average crawl time for medium-sized websites (50–100 pages) ranged between **2–5 minutes**
- Graph visualization rendered smoothly for up to **1,000 nodes**
- AI query response time averaged **2–4 seconds**
- Worker-based execution ensured stable performance without blocking the frontend

The asynchronous architecture significantly improved scalability and responsiveness.

9.4 Comparison with Existing Solutions

Feature	Traditional Scanners	Manual Recon	AETHER
Automated Crawling	Partial	No	Yes
Graph Visualization	No	No	Yes
AI-Assisted Analysis	No	No	Yes
Legal Authorization Enforcement	No	No	Yes
Modular Architecture	Limited	No	Yes
Cloud-Native Design	Partial	No	Yes

Table 9.1 : Comparison with Existing Solutions

Compared to existing tools, AETHER provides **better interpretability**, **automation**, and **AI-driven insights** without engaging in exploitative actions.

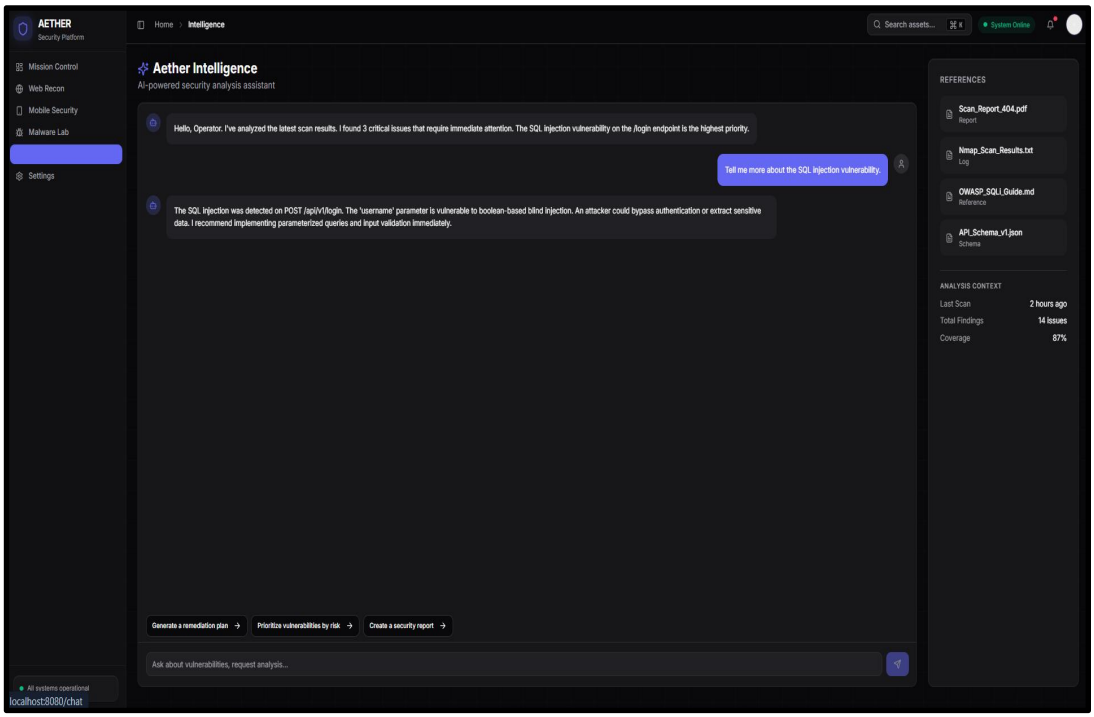

Figure 9.3 : RAG LLM

9.5 Error Analysis

During testing, the following errors were observed:

1. **Network Timeouts** during deep crawling of slow websites
2. **False-positive asset duplication** due to URL parameter variations
3. **Rate-limiting issues** when scanning aggressively configured targets
4. **Incomplete rendering** for JavaScript-heavy pages without headless browsing

These issues were mitigated using retry logic, URL normalization, crawl depth limits, and Playwright-based crawling.

9.6 Discussion of Observations

The experimental results indicate that AETHER successfully bridges the gap between traditional reconnaissance tools and modern AI-driven analysis. The graph-based representation significantly enhanced situational awareness by exposing hidden relationships between assets. The AI-assisted query mechanism reduced manual effort in analyzing large volumes of scan data.

However, the system emphasizes **defensive intelligence gathering** and does not automate exploitation, aligning with ethical and legal standards. The modular architecture allows future enhancements without redesigning the entire system.

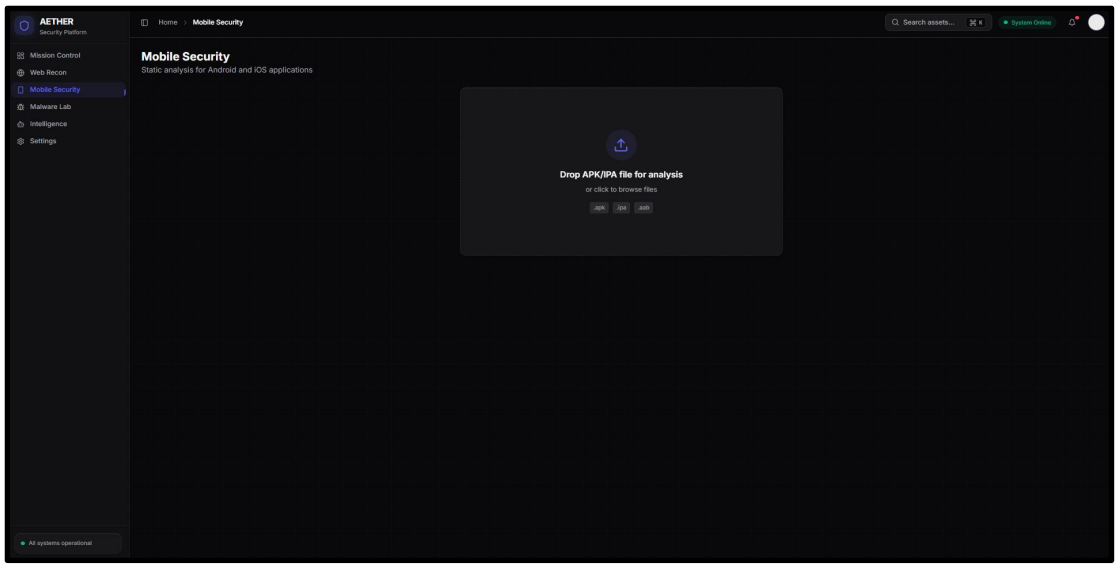

Figure 9.4 : Mobile Application Security

9.7 Chapter Summary

This chapter presented the results obtained from implementing and testing the AETHER platform. The outputs demonstrated effective attack surface mapping, visualization, and AI-assisted reasoning. Performance evaluations showed that the system is scalable and responsive, while comparative analysis highlighted its advantages over existing approaches. Identified errors and limitations provide valuable insights for further optimization. The next chapter concludes the project and outlines future enhancements.

CHAPTER 10

CONCLUSION

The rapid expansion of web-based applications and digital services has significantly increased the complexity of modern cyber infrastructures, making traditional manual reconnaissance and analysis approaches insufficient. In response to this challenge, this project presented **AETHER**, an AI-assisted, modular, and legally compliant platform for automated web reconnaissance, attack surface mapping, and intelligent security analysis.

AETHER integrates focused web crawling, graph-based visualization, controlled execution of reconnaissance tools, and AI-powered reasoning to provide a unified view of an organization's external digital footprint. By structuring discovered assets into interactive graphs and storing reconnaissance outputs in a secure and scalable manner, the system enables security analysts to understand relationships between endpoints, services, and exposed resources more effectively. The inclusion of a Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) based conversational interface further enhances usability by allowing users to query scan results and receive contextual, evidence-backed insights.

The proposed system emphasizes ethical usage, authorization validation, and non-exploitative analysis, ensuring compliance with legal and organizational security policies. Experimental results demonstrated that AETHER improves visibility, reduces manual effort, and offers better interpretability when compared to existing fragmented reconnaissance tools.

In conclusion, AETHER successfully addresses the limitations of existing reconnaissance methodologies by combining automation, visualization, and AI-driven intelligence into a single extensible platform. The system lays a strong foundation for future enhancements such as continuous monitoring, vulnerability prioritization, and predictive risk analytics, thereby contributing meaningfully to modern cybersecurity assessment practices.

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JOURNAL/IEEE CONFERENCE PUBLICATIONS

This project is suitable for submission to:

- IEEE International Conference on Cyber Security and Resilience
- IEEE Conference on Trust, Security and Privacy
- ACM CCS Student Research Competition
- Springer Journal of Cybersecurity

APPENDIX

Appendix A: Configuration and Environment Details

This appendix documents the general configuration parameters and environment setup used during the development and execution of the AETHER system. These details are provided to support reproducibility and system understanding.

A.1 System Environment

- Operating System: Linux (Ubuntu / Kali Linux for worker environment)
- Development Machine: Standard x86_64 architecture
- Browser Used: Google Chrome / Mozilla Firefox
- Internet Connectivity: Required for crawling, API access, and AI services

A.2 Deployment Environment

- Frontend: Vercel (Serverless hosting)
- Backend API: Vercel Serverless Functions
- Worker Node: Self-hosted VM / Container
- Authentication & Database: Supabase
- Storage: Supabase Object Storage

Appendix B: Supported Reconnaissance Tools

The AETHER platform integrates and orchestrates commonly used reconnaissance tools in a controlled and sandboxed manner.

Tool Name	Purpose
Nmap	Network and service discovery
Nikto	Web server configuration analysis
WhatWeb	Technology fingerprinting
Dirsearch / Gobuster	Directory and endpoint discovery
Custom Crawler	Sitemap and link graph generation

All tools are executed with strict scope validation, timeouts, and authorization checks.

Appendix C: AI and RAG Configuration

This appendix outlines the high-level configuration of the Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) pipeline used in AETHER.

Data Sources:

- Crawled web page content
- Parsed scan results
- Metadata and headers

Processing Steps:

- Text extraction and chunking
- Vector embedding generation
- Project-level indexing

Query Handling:

- User queries are matched against stored vectors
- Responses are generated using retrieved context
- Outputs are grounded in project-specific data

This approach ensures contextual accuracy and minimizes hallucination.

Appendix D: Security and Legal Safeguards

The following safeguards are enforced at the system level:

- Mandatory user authentication
- Explicit confirmation of target authorization
- Blocking of private IP ranges and localhost targets
- Rate limiting and scan throttling
- Audit logging of scan initiation and access
- Role-based access control for projects

These safeguards ensure ethical and lawful operation of the platform.